上海交通大学学位论文

《紫色》2023 年电影改编版与原著小说叙事话语比较分析

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申请学位层次： 学士

2025 年 06 月

A Dissertation Submitted to

Shanghai Jiao Tong University for Bachelor Degree

A COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF THE NARRATIVE DISCOURSE IN THE 2023 MOVIE ADAPTATION AND THE ORIGINAL NOVEL OF *THE COLOR PURPLE*

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June 3rd, 2025

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摘 要

本文以爱丽丝·沃克的小说《紫色》及其2023年歌舞电影改编版为研究对象，基于热奈特叙事话语理论和斯坦策尔叙事情境理论，从叙事时间、叙事声音和叙事情境三个维度，对比分析两种不同艺术表现形式的叙事差异。研究发现，小说通过书信体的碎片化叙事、非线性的时序（如倒叙与预叙）以及重复性文字，深刻呈现了黑人女性塞莉从压迫到觉醒的个体历程；而2023年电影则借助视听蒙太奇、音乐吟唱与舞蹈编排，将文本时间转化为动态的感官体验，通过时序重构、时距延展与频率转换，实现了从文学到电影的创造性转化。此外，电影在叙事情境上灵活切换中立型、人物型与作者型视角，强化了群体叙事的文化意义。本研究揭示了不同艺术表现形式在叙事的"艺术加工"的共性逻辑，为文学改编电影的理论与实践提供了新视角。

关键词：叙事话语，《紫色》，热奈特叙事话语理论，斯坦策尔叙事情境，文学改编

ABSTRACT

This study focuses on Alice Walker's novel, *The Color Purple*, and its 2023 musical movie adaptation as the primary subjects of analysis. Utilizing Gérard Genette's framework of narrative discourse alongside Franz K. Stanzel's theory of narrative situations, the study examines the narrative distinctions between these two artistic mediums across three dimensions: narrative time, narrative voice, and narrative situation. The findings indicate that the novel, characterized by its fragmented epistolary structure, nonlinear chronology (including analepsis and prolepsis), and repetitive language, effectively conveys the personal evolution of the African American protagonist, Celie, from oppression to self-discovery. In contrast, the 2023 movie employs audiovisual montage, musical elements, and choreographed dance to transform narrative time into an engaging sensory experience. Through the reconfiguration of temporal sequences, the extension of narrative duration, and the modification of narrative frequency, the movie successfully executes a creative transmedial adaptation from literature to cinema. Additionally, the movie adeptly navigates between neutral, character-bound, and authorial narrative perspectives, thereby enhancing the cultural significance of collective storytelling. This study elucidates the underlying principles of "artistic processing" that traverse various narrative forms and provides fresh insights into both the theoretical and practical aspects of literary-to-film adaptation.

Key words: Narrative Discourse, *The Color Purple,* Genette's theory of narrative discourse, Stanzel's narrative situations, literary adaptation.

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Chapter One Introduction

1.1 Introduction

The Color Purple, an epistolary novel by the esteemed African American author Alice Walker, was published in 1982. The work received widespread acclaim, winning the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction, the National Book Award, and the National Book Critics Circle Award in 1983. Newsweek praised it as "a permanently important novel" (Shi, 1986, p. 16). The narrative was first adapted into a movie in 1985 by the renowned director Steven Spielberg, achieving significant success and earning multiple Academy Award nominations. In 2023, the novel was once again adapted into a musical movie directed by Blitz Bazawule, with Spielberg returning as a producer. This latest adaptation highlights the enduring significance and profound impact of the novel's themes and values on contemporary audiences, even as time has passed.

In crafting the novel, Walker employed African American vernacular and a stark, unembellished narrative style to create a series of letters through which the protagonist, Celie, articulates her sorrows to God and her sister, Nettie. The language used in the novel is infused with Southern Black dialect, characterized by frequent spelling and grammatical errors that reflect Celie's identity as a poorly educated Black woman from a rural farming background in Georgia (Shi, 1986). The structure of the novel, as an epistolary work, consists of ninety-two letters that collectively form a cohesive narrative. Seventy of these letters are written by Celie, utilizing semi-literate African American English, and serve to propel the plot forward. The narrative begins with analepsis and incorporates a blend of straightforward and embedded narratives, employing a variety of narrative techniques that extend beyond mere first-person or third-person perspectives (Yang, 1989). The initial

fifty-one letters consist of Celie's tragic and confessional monologues directed toward God (Hong, 2017). From the fifty-second letter onward, the narrative perspective shifts to Nettie, who recounts her experiences in Africa following her departure from home, detailing the suffering of the Olinka tribe and the oppression faced by African peoples (Morgan et al., 1997).

In the latter sections of the novel, Celie writes fourteen letters to her sister Nettie, embarking on a profound journey of self-discovery and identity formation. The final letter, which lacks a specific addressee, signifies a shift toward a more public narrative voice (Harris, 1984). Through these 92 letters, Celie recounts her life story, beginning as a naïve 14-year-old girl who endures repeated sexual abuse by her stepfather and is forced to relinquish her children. She is subsequently married off to Mr. _, who objectifies her both as a sexual being and as a domestic servant. Celie's transformation begins when she provides compassionate care for Shug Avery, Mr. _'s ailing mistress. Inspired by Celie's nurturing, Shug encourages her to seek independence and reveals the long-buried letters from Nettie. These pivotal experiences prompt Celie to reassess her faith in God and ultimately decide to leave Mr. _ to relocate to Memphis with Shug. In Memphis, she establishes her own pants-making business, gradually achieving financial autonomy and a sense of self-worth. By the conclusion of the novel, Celie inherits her mother's house following the death of Alphonso. Nettie returns to the United States with her husband, missionary Samuel, and their children, Olivia and Adam. After three decades of separation, the sisters are finally reunited (Warhol, 2001).

The 2023 movie adaptation preserves the fundamental themes and narrative structure of the novel while employing a linear storytelling approach to create a cohesive narrative. Due to the constraints inherent in the movie medium, the director was required to condense the entire storyline into a 140-minute runtime. Consequently, significant temporal milestones were highlighted, and the narrative was presented sequentially, enhanced by

musical performances that serve as extensions of the story. The story in the movie version begins in 1909, depicting the traumatic experience of 14-year-old Celie, who is raped by her stepfather, Alfonso, and subsequently forced to give up her two children. Following her mother's death, Celie is coerced into marriage with Mr. _, where she continues to endure both physical and emotional abuse. In the 1910s, Nettie comes to live with Celie but is soon expelled after rejecting Mr. _'s advances, leading Celie to believe that Nettie has died, which results in her profound isolation (Berlant, 1988). Later, Sofia marries Harpo, and her defiant spirit serves as a stark contrast to Celie's submissiveness. After Celie encourages Harpo to physically assault Sofia out of jealousy, she ultimately experiences remorse, leading to reconciliation and the formation of a strong bond between the two women.

In 1922, the character of Shug Avery, a jazz singer and lover of Mr. _, enters Celie's life, catalyzing a profound awakening of her self-identity. Their relationship evolves into a romantic bond, and during the 1930s, with Shug's assistance, Celie uncovers a series of concealed letters from her sister Nettie, who has become a missionary in Africa. These letters reveal critical information, including the fact that Alfonso is Celie's stepfather and that her biological father was murdered by white individuals. Motivated by Shug, Celie ultimately leaves Mr. _, moves to Memphis, and establishes her own pants business. The narrative progresses into the 1940s, marked by Alfonso's death and Celie's inheritance of her mother's estate. Nettie returns from Africa accompanied by Olivia and Adam, leading to a long-awaited reunion between the sisters after three decades. The movie concludes with a dinner scene in which Celie extends forgiveness to Mr. _. Through the climactic musical number I'm Here, she achieves redemption and reaffirms her relentless quest for freedom and dignity in the face of oppression.

From the preceding review of the movie's plot, it is evident that while the 2023 adaptation retains the novel's core storyline—Celie's abuse, her transformative relationship with Shug Avery, and her eventual reunion with Nettie—it fundamentally restructures the

narrative into a linear progression. Major life events are accentuated through music and choreography, replacing the novel's introspective letters and internal monologues with externalized expressions such as visual symbolism, lyrical refrains, and ensemble performances. Voiceovers are minimized, and the narrative's interiority is translated into collective, performative modes of storytelling.

This transformation reveals a profound shift in narrative technique between the novel and the movie. Consequently, this study will employ Gérard Genette's theory of narrative discourse and Franz K. Stanzel's theory of narrative situation to examine how the adaptation reconstructs the narrative structure of *The Color Purple*. By focusing on three key dimensions—narrative time, narrative voice, and narrative situation—this analysis explores how the movie reconfigures the original narrative structure and adopts distinctive cross-media storytelling strategies.

1.2 Literature Review

In the realm of international academic research, both Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* and its 1985 cinematic adaptation have been extensively analyzed in relation to their narrative discourse. Numerous scholars have approached this subject from diverse perspectives, thereby enriching the discussion with a wide range of insights. Given the limited scholarly engagement with the 2023 movie adaptation, this study employs previous comparative analyses between the original literary work and the 1985 movie to establish its analytical framework.

Regarding the narrative analysis of the novel *Alice Walker: Critical Perspectives Past and Present* (1993), edited by the esteemed African American literary critic Henry Louis Gates Jr. and others, this compilation features significant book reviews and sixteen scholarly essays focused on Walker's oeuvre. Among these contributions, Bell Hooks offers an in-depth exploration of the narrative strategies employed in *The Color Purple*. Additionally, numerous feminist critics have shown a keen interest in Walker's narrative theory. Notable works, such as Susan Sniader Lanser's *Toward a Feminist Narratology*

(1986) and *Fictions of Authority: Women Writers and Narrative Voice* (1992), as well as Rachel Blau Duplessis's *Writing Beyond the Ending: Narrative Strategies of Twentieth-Century Women Writers* (1985), include chapters that analyze the aesthetic significance of feminist narrative techniques in Walker's fiction. Furthermore, many critics have focused on the novel's epistolary structure and narrative methodologies. The incorporation of letters is pivotal, as it allows readers to engage deeply with the inner lives of Celie and Nettie, thereby facilitating a profound understanding of their suffering, struggles, and persistent quest for identity within a patriarchal framework (Tucker, 1988).

In the context of literary adaptation into movie, scholars predominantly investigate the overarching principles of cross-medium transformation, particularly focusing on the narrative techniques employed in the adapted movie versions compared to those in the original novels. Seymour Chatman, employing a macro-narratological approach, systematically contrasts the fundamental narrative forms of novels and movies. He argues that novels, through their descriptive passages, can interrupt the narrative flow, allowing readers the opportunity to construct individualized interpretations of scenes and characters. Conversely, movies, being predominantly visual, typically maintain a quicker pace and often lack the same degree of descriptive richness and reflective depth (Chatman, 1980). Specific analyses of the adaptation of *The Color Purple* indicate that the movie simplifies several narrative components. For instance, character development is somewhat diminished; Shug's rebellious nature and her intricate relationship with Celie are not explored as thoroughly as in the novel (Boutan, 2011). Thematically, while the movie successfully conveys the central arc of Celie's transformation from subjugation to empowerment, it diverges from the novel in certain key emphases. For instance, the portrayal of Albert (Mr. _) in the movie softens his character and minimizes his eventual moral reckoning, thereby shifting the narrative focus away from the novel's critique of patriarchal violence. As a result, the movie alters the original message by reducing the complexity of male accountability and diluting the novel's emphasis on personal transformation as a prerequisite for gender reconciliation (Moin et al., 2024). Some scholars, including Ishmael Reed, have also critiqued Spielberg's movie for its representation of Black identity, arguing that the depiction of Black men as "soulless monsters" constitutes a detrimental distortion (Reed, 2023).

In the realm of Chinese academia, significant advancements have been made in the narrative studies of movie adaptations of literary works. Extensive research has been conducted on *The Color Purple* and its cinematic interpretations, encompassing comprehensive discussions on the narrative strategies employed in these adaptations.

Many Chinese scholars focus on the interplay between narrative techniques and thematic expression. Both the original novel and its movie adaptation highlight themes of patriarchal oppression and female resistance within African American communities; however, they differ in their perspectives on gender. The novel promotes gender harmony, as illustrated by Mr. _'s transformation after Celie's departure, during which he takes up sewing. In contrast, the movie omits this character development, depicting Mr. _as chaotic and disconnected from Celie, with no reconciliation as portrayed in the novel. Scholars attribute this change to the movie's intention to appeal to mainstream audiences and boost box office performance, thereby retaining only the more "acceptable" aspects of female resistance while excluding the concept of gender harmony, which was less palatable to contemporary mainstream society (Zhou, 2006).

With regard to racial and religious themes, the novel and movie employ distinct narrative approaches. Walker celebrates African cultural traditions, suggesting that African American women draw strength from them. The correspondence between Celie and Nettie serves to connect Africa and America, symbolically representing a "root-seeking" journey. In contrast, the movie simplifies Nettie's journey to Africa (Fu, 2011). Concerning religious themes, the novel portrays Shug as independent and free-spirited, asserting that "God is neither 'she' nor 'he' but an 'it'" (Walker, 1982,p. 279). However, the movie introduces a scene in which Shug seeks forgiveness from her preacher father, indicating a retreat to traditional Christianity and thereby diminishing the feminist religious discourse present in the novel (Zhou, 2006).

In examining the transformations of narrative strategies between the novel and its movie adaptation, Chinese scholars frequently analyze the epistolary structure and the "quilt" narrative technique employed in the novel (Chen, 2017). The movie emphasizes key letters and retains Celie's perspective to minimize directorial interference, thereby preserving the narrative advantages of the original text (Ying and Wang, 2015). Furthermore, the 1985 movie innovatively utilizes montage to navigate time and space,

ensuring narrative coherence while adapting the novel's structure. Visual symbols—such as purple flowers and red decorations—effectively translate the novel's symbolic imagery into cinematic language, although certain plot modifications were necessary to accommodate visual storytelling (Ying and Wang, 2015). Additionally, scholars have explored how these adaptations influence character development. Overall, studies of movie adaptations by Chinese scholars engage with both macro and micro narrative techniques, comparing narrative subjects, constructing narrative rhythm, and analyzing differences in structural design (Yang, 2020).

In conclusion, the majority of both domestic and international research has predominantly concentrated on the original novel and the 1985 movie adaptation, encompassing a diverse array of perspectives. Nevertheless, there exists a considerable deficiency in the academic investigation of the 2023 movie adaptation, which presents a unique opportunity for scholarly analysis. The 2023 adaptation creatively integrates musical elements and choreography into its narrative framework, employing modified lyrics to convey psychological nuances and plot developments. The emotive capacity of music and dance enhances audience engagement with the characters' emotional states and the progression of the narrative. Consequently, the incorporation of musical and performative components, alongside transformations in emotional expression, provides a distinctive reinterpretation of the original novel, rendering it an exemplary subject for comprehensive analysis through the lens of classical narratology.

Therefore, this study aims to bridge the existing research gap by focusing on the 2023 musical movie adaptation of *The Color Purple.* While previous scholarship has predominantly addressed the narrative strategies in the original novel and the 1985 movie, few studies have examined how the 2023 version reshapes narrative discourse by integrating music, choreography, and emotionally expressive performance. This study concentrates on three core aspects of narrative transformation—narrative time, narrative voice, and narrative situation—as articulated by classical narratologists such as Gérard Genette and Franz Stanzel. By applying these theoretical lenses to the 2023 movie, the thesis explores how temporal structuring, shifts in narrative perspective, and narrative framing are reinterpreted within the cinematic-musical medium. Ultimately, the literature

reviewed herein not only establishes the critical foundation for this analysis but also highlights the pressing need for a narratological examination of this latest adaptation, thereby situating this research within ongoing academic conversations on intermedial storytelling and feminist narrative discourse.

1.3 Structure of the Thesis

This thesis is organized into six chapters, each addressing a distinct aspect of the comparative narrative analysis between *The Color Purple* novel and its 2023 movie adaptation.

Chapter One introduces the research background, outlines the narrative content of the novel and the movie, and reviews relevant literature. It situates the current study within ongoing scholarly discussions while identifying the research gap this thesis aims to fill.

Chapter Two presents the theoretical framework and research methodology. It begins with an overview of Gérard Genette's and Franz Stanzel's classical narratological theories, which underpin the analysis. The chapter then defines the three core dimensions of narrative discourse explored in this study: narrative time, narrative voice, and narrative situation.

Chapter Three provides a comparative analysis of narrative time in the novel and the movie. It explores the differences in narrative order, duration, and frequency, illustrating how the linear temporal structure of the movie contrasts with the fragmented, retrospective temporality of the novel.

Chapter Four examines the transformation of narrative voice. It analyzes how the introspective, epistolary voice in the novel is replaced by externalized, performative expressions in the movie, with particular attention to shifts in focalization and the narrator's presence.

Chapter Five discusses the narrative situation, focusing on how the novel's internal, monologic perspective shifts to a more public, dramatized mode of storytelling in the movie. It explores changes in narrative distance, perspective, and the implied audience.

Finally, Chapter Six summarizes the main findings, reflects on the implications of the narrative transformations across media, and suggests directions for further research. This

conclusion reinforces the thesis's contribution to the fields of narratology, adaptation studies, and feminist literary criticism.

Chapter Two Research Methods

2.1 Overview of Genette and Stanzel's Narrative Frameworks

This research employs Gérard Genette's theory of narrative discourse and Franz K. Stanzel's theory of narrative situation to analyze the narrative transformation in the 2023 movie adaptation of *The Color Purple* in comparison with Alice Walker's original novel. These two classical narratological frameworks offer systematic tools to examine changes in storytelling structure, narrative voice, and perspective across different media forms.

Genette's model, developed in his seminal work *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method*, offers comprehensive tools for analyzing narrative time (order, duration, frequency) and narrative voice (who speaks, who perceives). These concepts are crucial for understanding how the original novel, structured as an epistolary narrative, manipulates time and perspective to convey Celie's psychological development and fragmented reality.

However, Genette's structuralist framework does not fully address the relational dynamics between the narrator, characters, and audience, particularly in multimedia contexts such as movie. Therefore, this study also incorporates Franz K. Stanzel's typology of narrative situations—namely, the authorial, figural, and neutral modes—to capture the broader discursive positioning of the narrator within the story world. Stanzel's theory offers a complementary macro-perspective that illuminates how the adapted movie reconfigures point of view and emotional engagement through visual and auditory techniques.

By integrating Genette's micro-level structural analysis with Stanzel's macro-level situational framework, this chapter establishes a comprehensive analytical lens for comparing the narrative techniques in the novel and its 2023 adaptation. The following sections outline the key concepts of each theory and explain how they will be applied in both textual and cinematic analyses.

Since the invention of the motion picture camera by the Lumière brothers in 1895, cinema has profoundly transformed human cognitive frameworks through its unique representation of reality. As movie emerged as the dominant artistic medium of the 20th

century, the interplay and mutual influence between movie and literature intensified. Although novels and movies are recognized as distinct artistic forms, they exhibit significant differences in their methods of storytelling, modes of expression, and audience engagement. Movie theorist Iwasaki Akira argues that literature conveys ideas through descriptive imagery, thereby influencing the human psyche, while movie primarily employs the continuous presentation of images to communicate concepts. The language of literature has an abstract impact on the mind, whereas movie engages the senses directly (Iwasaki, 1982). Consequently, adapting a novel into a movie involves translating the internal thoughts and emotions of the literary work into a visual format, transforming abstract ideas into tangible visual experiences. Nevertheless, both language and imagery are components of a broader semiotic system, and both art forms serve a narrative function. As Chen asserts, "Narrativity is the strongest intermediary linking novels and movies, and the visual and textual languages exhibit a strong tendency for mutual permeability" (Chen, 1988). Furthermore, Seymour Chatman's concept of "narrative duality" in *Story and Discourse* provides a theoretical framework for cross-media adaptation: "Any narrative work contains two levels: the story and the discourse, the former being the content of the narrative, and the latter the manner of expression" (Chatman, 1980). While not the core theoretical basis of this study, Chatman's model helps to reveal the structural comparability between the two media, thereby providing an essential conceptual foundation for cross-media narrative analysis.

In order to achieve a comprehensive understanding of the narrative transformation in the 2023 musical adaptation of *The Color Purple*, it is necessary to adopt a narratological framework that captures both structural and experiential dimensions of storytelling. A comparison of the 2023 adaptation with the original epistolary novel and Spielberg's 1985 movie version reveals several key features of what Marie-Laure Ryan and other scholars have described as postclassical narratology. Postclassical narratology is a mode of narrative analysis that expands beyond text-centered formalism to incorporate media specificity, embodied experience, and multimodality (Ryan, 2004). The integration of music, choreography, and symbolic visual elements in the movie transforms narrative events into affective performances, thereby shifting the focus from plot mechanics to emotional resonance and audience immersion.

These postclassical characteristics underscore the necessity to examine not only the content of the story, but also the manner in which it is conveyed across different media. To this end, this study employs Gérard Genette's theory of narrative discourse—focusing on narrative time and narrative voice—to analyze the movie's structural deviations from the original text (Genette, 1980). Concurrently, Franz K. Stanzel's theory of narrative situation proffers a complementary framework for interpreting the movie's shifting perspectives and character focalization (Stanzel, 1984). The integration of these two narratological models facilitates a systematic comparison of the novel and its adaptation, elucidating how the 2023 movie reconfigures narrative elements through cross-media storytelling.

2.2 Narrative Time

Narrative plays a pivotal role in both cinematic and literary forms. In these artistic mediums, narratives progress and evolve through a coherent logical framework over time, with temporal elements serving as both the inception and conclusion of logical narration. As articulated by Andy Plaks, "The unity and completeness of narration are determined by the narrative's 'causal law' and 'temporalization' standards" (Plaks, 2014, p. 56). The foundational structure of novels and movies has been extensively analyzed by structuralist narratologist Tzvetan Todorov in his seminal work, *Structural Analysis of Narrative*, where he investigates the concepts of story time (temps de l'histoire) and discourse time (temps du discours). Todorov succinctly asserts, "One of the forms that transforms discourse into story information is the time of the narrative; this issue arises because of two interrelated time relations: one is the temporality of the depicted world, and the other is the temporality of the language that depicts this world" (Todorov, 1969). Building upon Todorov's insights, French narratologist Gérard Genette further examines the interplay between story time and discourse time in his influential text, *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method*, where he introduces three fundamental components of narrative time: order, duration, and frequency.

In the realm of narrative, both literary and cinematic forms exhibit distinct temporal characteristics. When engaging with a novel, readers experience a tangible flow of time, as authors often provide extensive descriptions that facilitate an expansive temporal experience within the text. Novels construct time through linguistic expression, prioritizing

time while treating space as a subordinate element. The linear nature of text prevents multiple words from being perceived simultaneously, thereby emphasizing the sequential unfolding of time. Conversely, in movie, a still frame represents a spatial construct, with the narrative progressing through changes in space. Audiences primarily engage with spatial elements, while the passage of time is less overt, suggesting a simultaneous experience of time. As noted by George Bluestone, the foundational principle of novels is time, whereas that of movies is space. Novels utilize hypothetical spaces to develop their narratives through complex temporal values, while movies employ hypothetical time to shape their narratives through spatial configurations (Bluestone, 1957, p. 66). Despite the differing presentations of time and space in literature and movie, this does not indicate a complete dichotomy between the two. Consequently, there exists a transferable dimension in the examination of narrative time across both mediums.

In narratological theory, narration encompasses a dual temporal sequence, consisting of both the time of the events being narrated and the time of the narrative itself, which is inherently semi-fictional. Genette asserts that within a narrative, multiple temporalities can coexist, rendering the story's temporal framework multi-dimensional. However, the narrator must disrupt the "natural" sequence to impose a linear structure on narrative time (Genette, 1980, p. 127). Genette identifies three fundamental components of narrative time: order, duration, and frequency.

Order refers to the sequence of events within a story and their arrangement in the narrative. Analyzing order involves examining the relationships between the time of the story and the (pseudo-) time of the narrative (Genette, 1980, p. 35). According to Genette, narrative time has a dual nature, encompassing both signified time and signifying time. Investigating narrative time sequences requires comparing the arrangement of events or temporal segments within the narrative discourse (Genette, 1980, p. 35). The term "anachrony" broadly refers to any inconsistency between two temporal sequences. "Prolepsis" denotes narrative elements that anticipate or recount future events (flashforward), while "analepsis" refers to retrospective narratives that recount events occurring prior to the current point in the story (flashback). By identifying anachronies such as analepsis (flashback) and prolepsis (flashforward), this study will explore how the novel's layered temporal structure — especially Celie's retrospective narration through

letters — is adapted or reconfigured in the movie, which employs a more linear and dramatized timeline to align with musical conventions and cinematic clarity.

Duration refers to the "connections between the variable duration of these events in the story and the pseudo-temporal order of their arrangement in the narrative" (Genette Genette, 1980, pp.94-95). This concept encapsulates the relationship between the actual duration of events within the narrative and the textual length devoted to recounting them. In his exploration of New Narrative Discourse, Genette delineates four traditional narrative movements: "Pause," "Scene," "Summary," and "Ellipsis," which he addresses with notable flexibility. He employs the following formulas to clarify the temporal values associated with these movements:

Pause: NT = n, ST = 0; therefore, NT > ST.

Scene: NT = ST

Summary: NT is less than ST

Ellipsis: NT = 0, ST = n; therefore, NT < ST (Genette, 1980, pp. 94-95)

Genette distinguishes between narrative time, which refers to the duration during which the narrator recounts the story, and story time, which denotes the temporal setting of the events. A "Pause" indicates that narrative time exceeds story time, while a "Scene" suggests that narrative time is nearly equivalent to story time. A "Summary" implies that narrative time is shorter than story time, and "Ellipsis" denotes that narrative time is significantly less than story time.

In this study, these distinctions will be used to compare how specific scenes—such as moments of trauma, reunion, or personal growth—are expanded or condensed in the movie. For instance, the movie's musical numbers tend to "pause" narrative progression in favor of emotional emphasis, while some parts of Celie's early life are summarized or elided entirely for cinematic pacing.

Frequency is defined as "the relation of frequency (or, more simply, of repetition)" (Genette 113). Genette categorizes narrative frequency into four distinct types, which can be succinctly represented through mathematical formulas. He posits that any narrative can recount an event once (1N/1S), n times for events that occurred n times (nN/nS), n times for events that occurred once (nN/1S), or once for events that occurred n times (1N/nS) (Genette, 1980, pp.114-116). Notably, Genette asserts that the second type (nN/nS) can be

subsumed under (1N/1S), or vice versa, when n=1. Since the frequency of narration aligns with the frequency of the story, Genette ultimately regards both types as fundamentally equivalent, coining the term "simple narration." Consequently, these four categories of narrative frequency can be streamlined into three: simple (1N/1S, nN/nS), repetitive (nN/1S), and iterative (1N/nS).

Genette's categories—singulative, repetitive, and iterative—will help analyze how recurring motifs (e.g., abuse, letters, or singing) are differently emphasized in the novel and the movie. While the novel often iterates similar events through Celie's recurring letters, the movie may employ musical refrains or montage sequences to represent such repetition visually and aurally.

By applying these three dimensions of narrative time, this study demonstrates how the 2023 adaptation reinterprets the temporality of *The Color Purple,* transforming its epistolary, introspective rhythm into a visually dynamic and musically structured cinematic experience. This theoretical lens enables a focused comparative analysis of how temporal manipulation contributes to shifts in theme, tone, and audience engagement across media.

2.3 Narrative Voice

In the process of narrative construction, regardless of the artistic medium employed, the narrator's unique expression—evident through choices in language, tone, perspective, and discourse strategies—serves as a crucial link between the act of narration and the audience's interpretation (Aczel, 1998). The American scholar Wayne C. Booth conducted a comprehensive examination of the rhetorical role of narrative voice in his seminal work, *The Rhetoric of Fiction*, where he distinguished between the "implied author" and the narrator's voice. Booth argued that narrative voice functions not only as a mechanism for conveying information but also as a fundamental element in shaping the ethical and emotional dimensions of the text: "The voice of the narrator is the most direct way through which the implied author communicates with the reader, blending tone, attitude, and perspective into a coherent textual persona" (Booth, 1983, p. 150).

Additionally, Gérard Genette incorporated the concept of narrative voice into his analysis of the "act of narration" in *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method*,

distinguishing between "Who speaks" (narrative voice) and "Who perceives" (narrative mood). He argued that the essence of narrative voice resides in its role as "the narrator's linguistic projection at the discourse level," functioning as the mechanism through which the text establishes its authority, distance, and credibility (Genette, 1980, pp. 189-194). In my analysis, I will apply this distinction to examine how the homodiegetic narrator of the novel, Celie, contrasts with the movie's more visually mediated and heterodiegetic modes of storytelling, particularly where the movie modifies or reassigns narrative authority.

The discussion of narrative voice encompasses the topic of narrative discourse, specifically the narrative act, which pertains to the interplay between speech acts and thematic elements. The theme extends beyond the individual executing or experiencing the action to include all participants in the narrative activity, even those who are passively involved. Genette noted that linguistics took considerable time to clarify the subjectivity referenced by Benveniste in speech, which involves a shift from sentence analysis to an examination of the relationship between sentences and their producers—a process now referred to as the "narrative act" (Genette, 1980, p. 147). Through numerous examples, Genette illuminated the relationships among narrative and story, narrator and story, and narrator and characters, while also addressing the states and functions of narrators. The concept of narrative time, previously discussed in detail, will not be elaborated upon further in this context.

In the context of narrative analysis, the narrative level serves as a critical framework for examining the thematic elements of a novel and the narrative threads that comprise its plot, with each thread capable of constituting a complete narrative arc. Gérard Genette, in his work *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method*, categorizes narrative acts into three distinct levels: extradiegetic, intradiegetic, and metadiegetic. He posits that "the power relations between narrative levels determine the attribution of narrative authority" (Genette, 1980, p. 228). The extradiegetic level pertains to the literary act occurring at the highest level, while the intradiegetic level refers to the narrative of a character presented at the primary level, which is often imbued with greater significance and practicality than the extradiegetic level. Genette asserts that each narrative level possesses its own thematic concerns and is interrelated. Any event recounted within a narrative exists at a story level that is immediately subordinate to the level of the narrative act that generated it.

Consequently, the narrative subject of the first narrative is classified as the extra-story subject, whereas the second narrative, or meta-story, is identified as the story subject. The metanarrative level encompasses the narrative component that is integrated within the primary story. There are two principal types of relationships between the metanarrative and the primary narrative into which it is embedded: the first is a direct causal relationship between the events of the meta-story and those of the primary narrative, which endows the second narrative with an explanatory role; the second involves the prophetic function of a flashforward within the meta-story, which anticipates the implications of the narrative situation at the primary level without referencing antecedent events (Genette, 1980, pp. 227-242). In literary works, this multilayered structure is frequently realized through epistolary forms or frame narratives, whereas in cinematic representations, narrative layers are translated into visual dimensions. Bluestone observes that the "temporal structure" of novels necessitates a linear progression of narrative layers, while the "spatial structure" of movies permits the juxtaposition or even overlap of these layers (Bluestone, 1957, p. 73). For instance, the novel's epistolary structure establishes an extradiegetic narrator who introduces Celie's voice as intradiegetic, while her letters to God or Nettie sometimes embed metadiegetic narratives. I will analyze how this layering of narrative levels enables subjective interiority and personal transformation in the novel. In contrast, the movie translation compresses or visualizes these layers differently—through musical interludes, mise-en-scène, or visual motifs—necessitating a reassessment of how metadiegetic content is presented without explicit narration.

Genette further categorizes narrators into two types: heterodiegetic and homodiegetic, with the primary distinction being whether the narrator participates in the events of the story (Genette,1980, p. 245). A heterodiegetic narrator does not engage with the story world and lacks a direct connection to the characters and events depicted. In literary narratives, this often manifests as an omniscient viewpoint, functioning as an external observer of the entire narrative. In movie, a heterodiegetic narrator typically appears as a voice-over or employs camera techniques, such as panoramic shots or editing rhythms, to create an omniscient effect. Conversely, a homodiegetic narrator is actively involved in the story world, narrating from the perspective of a character, usually in the first person, although third-person narration may also occur. In cinematic contexts, this corresponds to

first-person voice-over narration or a pseudo-documentary style. The novel features a homodiegetic narrator—Celie—who recounts her life in the first person, creating a sense of intimacy and psychological depth. In the 2023 movie, this voice is visually displaced or transposed into songs, montage sequences, and symbolic imagery. By comparing these forms, I will examine how narrative voice is adapted across media, and how the shift from verbal to audiovisual storytelling affects the representation of Celie's agency and emotional growth.

Thus, in analyzing *The Color Purple* novel and its new adaptation into a musical movie, Genette's concepts of narrative voice and narrative levels from *Narrative Discourse* will be applied to perform a brief analysis of these aspects.

2.4 Narrative Situation

In order to more effectively distinguish between narrative situation and narrative voice, this study employs Franz K. Stanzel's theory of narrative situation to investigate the macro-structural dynamics of narration, particularly within the context of cinematic storytelling. While Gérard Genette's theory of narrative voice focuses on the identity of the speaker and the narrative level from which they articulate the story, Stanzel's framework emphasizes how the narrative is conveyed through the interplay among the narrator, characters, and audience.

This theoretical differentiation is particularly beneficial when examining the narrative strategies employed in *The Color Purple,* as the 1982 novel and the 2023 movie utilize fundamentally distinct mechanisms for constructing point of view and narrative authority. Genette's concept of homodiegetic narration in the novel positions Celie as both the narrator and a character, offering readers profound insight into her psychological development. Conversely, Stanzel's model allows for an analysis of how this subjective experience is recontextualized in the movie through changes in narrative situation.

Stanzel's theoretical framework was shaped by his mentor, Kate Hamburger, who made a distinction between fictional and non-fictional narratives. However, the pivotal innovation of Stanzel's theory lies in conceptualizing narrative as a "situational negotiation of intersubjectivity" (Stanzel, 1984, p. 4). Within his narrative theory, Stanzel synthesizes

the roles of the narrator, narrative perspective, and the phenomenon of mood into the overarching concept of narrative situation, positing that the ostensibly free structure of narrative serves merely as a superficial layer. He identifies the narrative techniques employed by authors—demonstrated to be effective yet relatively constrained—as the deeper structural elements of narrative, which he designates as the "narrative situation" (Chen, 2005). This notion underscores that narrative is not a static construct; rather, it constitutes an interactive space among the narrator, characters, and the reader or audience. Stanzel delineates three distinct types of narrative situations.

1. "Authorial narrative situation": In this scenario, the narrator assumes an omniscient role external to the story, exerting direct control over the narrative's progression. This situation aligns logically with Genette's concept of the "heterodiegetic narrator."

2. "Figural narrative situation": Here, the narrator remains concealed, and narrative information is conveyed through the perspective of a single character, devoid of omniscient intervention (Stanzel, 1984, p. 88). This represents a transition from the "voice of God" to "the words of mortals." A defining characteristic of this situation is the portrayal of the character's limited perspective and memory biases, which compel the reader or audience to actively engage in filling narrative gaps.

3. "Neutral narrative situation": This type solely documents external actions and dialogues, refraining from exploring the characters' internal thoughts or the narrator's evaluations (Stanzel,1984, p. 142).

Given that this study centers on the narrative analysis of *The Color Purple*, it will extend Genette's theory of narrative discourse by incorporating Stanzel's concept of narrative situation. Specifically, the research will investigate the dynamic transitions among authorial, figural, and neutral narrative situations to better fulfill the objectives of this analysis. The movie adaptation employs cinematic techniques such as close-ups and voice-overs to maintain the character perspective logic established in the original novel, thereby transforming Celie's psychological development into a visually articulated emotional narrative. This synthesis of theory and text not only addresses the limitations of Genette's analysis of narrative discourse concerning subject interactions but also provides a more varied explanatory framework for cross-media narrative interactions.

Through the combined application of Genette's structural narratology and Stanzel's narrative situation theory, this chapter establishes the conceptual and methodological groundwork for a comparative analysis of *The Color Purple* in its original literary form and its 2023 cinematic adaptation. By framing the investigation around the three interrelated dimensions of narrative time, narrative voice, and narrative situation, the study is positioned to explore how the adapted movie reconfigures the novel's storytelling mechanics across different media. The following chapter will apply this framework through close textual and visual analysis, aiming to uncover how the adaptation translates internal narrative structures into embodied, audiovisual experiences that resonate with contemporary audiences.

Chapter Three Narrative Time in the Novel and Movie

To examine the temporal restructuring in the 2023 movie adaptation of *The Color Purple*, this chapter employs Gérard Genette's model of narrative time—specifically, the dimensions of order, duration, and frequency—as analytical tools. Instead of reiterating Genette's theory in abstract terms, this analysis focuses on how each dimension is operationalized to underscore key differences between the temporal organization of the novel and that of the movie.

By investigating order, this chapter explores how the nonlinear, analeptic structure of the epistolary novel—particularly its fragmented revelation of Celie's past—is transformed into a predominantly linear progression in the movie. The analysis pays particular attention to how narrative pacing is managed in each medium, considering the condensation or expansion of key life events. Additionally, frequency is utilized to examine the use of repetition—through motifs, memory sequences, or musical refrains—and how these elements influence the emotional rhythm and viewer perception in the adaptation. Through this tripartite framework, the analysis reveals how the movie reconfigures time not only as a narrative structure but also as a medium for emotional and thematic expression.

3.1 Narrative Order in the Novel and Movie

Genette's concept of order emphasizes the importance of temporal arrangement in narrative and its impact on thematic expression. In Alice Walker's *The Color Purple*, both the novel and its movie adaptation challenge traditional linear storytelling by employing fragmented letter-based narration and audiovisual montage. This approach effectively illustrates the protagonist Celie's difficult journey from deep oppression to self-realization.

3.1.1 Narrative Order in the Novel

The original text of *The Color Purple* consists of 92 letters, which chronologically span from 1909 to the 1940s. The author, Alice Walker, does not provide explicit character

backgrounds or contextual details regarding the setting. Notably, these letters diverge from conventional correspondence, as some are unsigned and others are addressed to God (Zhang, 2014). Furthermore, the narrative is not structured in a linear fashion. Celie's initial letters subtly convey the trauma she endures. In her first letter, she states, "I am fourteen years old. I—I have always been a good girl. Maybe you can give me a sign letting me know what is happening to me" (Walker, 1982, p. 8). The phrase "what is happening to me" alludes to the sexual abuse inflicted by her stepfather, Alphonso. However, Celie refrains from explicitly detailing this experience, avoiding the term "rape" and instead hinting at her suffering through indirect inquiries. It is not until the 52nd letter that the truth is revealed: "But then I remember, he not my daddy, just my children daddy. What your mama do, ast Shug, rob the cradle?" (Walker, 1982, p. 98). This delayed revelation, conveyed through analepsis (flashback), gradually reconstructs the truth of Celie's early experiences, allowing the reader to engage in the reconstruction of narrative chronology and piece together the authentic sequence of events. This narrative technique also emphasizes that Celie required decades to confront her trauma and liberate herself from the self-repressive psychological mechanisms she had developed.

In the latter sections of the novel, the correspondence between Celie and her sister Nettie begins to alternate. For instance, Celie shares her daily psychological reflections with Nettie: "Maybe if I had stayed in Memphis last summer, it never would have happened. But I spent the summer fixing up the house" (Walker, 1982, p.117). Meanwhile, Nettie recounts her experiences in Africa: "We were married last fall in England, where we tried to get relief for the Olinka from the churches and the Missionary Society" (Walker, 1982, p. 110). Through this epistolary exchange, the narrative presents two parallel yet interconnected struggles: while Celie contends with patriarchal and racial oppression in the American South, Nettie confronts the cultural and colonial impositions faced by African communities. Despite the geographic distance, both women experience systemic silencing, marginalization, and a struggle for autonomy—Celie as a Black woman facing sexual abuse and domestic servitude, Nettie as a missionary navigating imperialist structures in Africa. Their letters gradually unveil the resilience they cultivate through knowledge-sharing and sisterhood, thus forming a transcontinental dialogue of resistance.

This juxtaposition of spatial and temporal elements, as letters traverse continents and

decades, highlights the shared experiences of oppression and resistance among Black women, regardless of their geographical locations. The asynchronous flow of their narratives emphasizes that such experiences are not isolated but resonate across borders, reinforcing a collective identity rooted in survival and solidarity.

The letter-based narrative structure of the novel allows Celie to reveal secrets in a fragmented manner. Furthermore, the letters are not constrained by a strict chronological order and can include memories or premonitions (prolepsis) at any point. However, a limitation of this narrative form is its "unidirectionality" — the reader is restricted to perceiving events solely from the perspectives of Celie and Nettie, while the inner lives and historical contexts of other characters remain obscured. Celie's semi-literate grammar, as exemplified by her statement, " I ast him to take me instead of Nettie while our new mammy sick," alerts the reader to the potential for omissions or distortions within her narrative (Walker, 1982, p. 23).

3.1.2 Narrative Order in the movie

The 2023 cinematic adaptation of *The Color Purple*, constrained by a runtime of 140 minutes, employs a linear narrative structure while simultaneously transcending temporal limitations through the integration of music and dance as vehicles of time. Additionally, it utilizes symbolic contrasts in color and spatial elements. Director Blitz Bazawule applies nonlinear editing techniques to dismantle the confines of a linear narrative. Director Blitz Bazawule employs montage as a key cinematic technique to reshape the narrative order and temporal experience of the original novel. Montage, in movie theory, refers to the editing technique that combines a series of shots to condense time, evoke emotion, or create symbolic meaning (Bordwell & Thompson, 2016). Through musical numbers, rapid visual transitions, symbolic use of color, and spatial juxtapositions, the movie compresses years of Celie's emotional development into a condensed, nonlinear audiovisual narrative. By incorporating montage editing and musical narration, the movie expands Gérard Genette's concept of "textual time" into a complex, multi-layered audiovisual experience. As a result, the events portrayed in the movie do not unfold in a straightforward, unidirectional manner; instead, they emerge as fragmented reflections that reconstruct the timeline, thereby illuminating Celie's unexpressed trauma and aspirations.

A notable example of montage occurs early in the movie. The sequence begins with a

tranquil scene of young Celie and her sister Nettie playing by a sunlit river, accompanied by a gentle musical score and a warm, golden color palette. This moment of innocence is immediately disrupted by a dynamic musical number that recounts Celie's abuse and her subsequent pregnancy (Bazawule, 2023). The montage includes quick cuts between Celie's distressed expressions, the physical assault, the birth of the child, and a church congregation singing jubilantly. The crescendo of the music intensifies the emotional contrast between the external religious celebration and Celie's internal turmoil. Here, music functions not merely as background but as a narrative agent: it compresses months of trauma into minutes and articulates unspeakable pain through melody and rhythm (Gorbman, 1987). The viewer simultaneously witnesses past abuse and present emotional consequences, creating a powerful temporal layering.

Beyond montage, the movie utilizes color and spatial metaphors to evoke anachrony in narrative time. In sequences that portray Celie's childhood and early oppression, the mise-en-scène adopts muted browns, greys, and dim lighting—emphasizing psychological repression and physical confinement. In contrast, moments of self-realization and empowerment — such as when Celie starts her sewing business — are marked by rich purples, sunlit rooms, and vibrant textiles (Bazawule, 2023). These visual cues do not always follow chronological order but instead serve as thematic motifs, recurring across different points in time to signal transformation. Thus, color in the movie is not merely decorative; it operates in tandem with montage to create anachrony, a non-sequential representation of time as defined by Genette (1980).

This technique is also evident in the musical scene *Two Women*, which encapsulates the emotional arc of Celie and Shug's developing relationship. In the novel, their relationship develops gradually through an extensive exchange of letters. Celie articulates her feelings in one letter, stating, "Shug, I say to her in my mind, Girl, you look like a real good time, the Good Lord knows you do" (Walker, 1982, p.275). This gradual psychological development relies on a linear progression of time. In contrast, the movie condenses this process into a blues duet. The camera alternates between their gazes, touches, and movements, while the lyrics "Will I see a new world in your eyes" (Bazawule, 2023) and "I want to be a story for me. That can believe forever" prefigure Celie's awakening (Bazawule, 2023).. This musical sequence functions as *prolepsis* — a

flash-forward in narrative — by symbolically foreshadowing Celie's emotional emancipation. Genette (1980) emphasizes that such anticipatory elements can manipulate the viewer's perception of time, and here, music fulfills that very function.

At the same time, the elaborate dance sequences further contribute to this temporal layering. Celie's bodily movements evolve across the narrative — from restrained and passive to expressive and commanding. The choreography's fluidity versus rigidity visually encodes her psychological transition. As she dances with more grounded posture and expanded gestures, the camera movement and editing rhythm slow down, signaling an embodied liberation (Bordwell & Thompson, 2016). These bodily rhythms participate in the movie's anachronic structure, linking past repression to future possibility within a single sequence.

Thus, the movie's nonlinear structure does not undermine its coherence but rather enriches its emotional and thematic complexity. By using montage, musical narration, and symbolic color schemes, the movie juxtaposes past trauma with future healing in a compact yet expressive form. These techniques compensate for the limited runtime of 140 minutes, allowing the moviemakers to convey the depth of Celie's psychological journey without adhering to strict chronological progression. In doing so, the movie expands the possibilities of Genette's theory of narrative order by translating literary anachrony into an audiovisual grammar unique to cinema.

The non-linear narrative structures of both the novel and its 2023 movie adaptation of *The Color Purple* carry profound cultural significance. The disjointed temporal order, whether presented through the epistolary format of the novel or the audiovisual montage of the movie, mirrors the fractured historical memory and lived experience of Black women under systemic oppression. These anachronies are not merely stylistic choices; they serve as a form of narrative resistance. As Homi Bhabha (1994) argues, "The time of the colonized must be fragmented and reconstructed in order to challenge hegemonic narratives" (p. 145). Within this framework, the fragmented temporality becomes a political act — disrupting Eurocentric, linear historical accounts and asserting a voice for those who have been historically silenced. The novel's delayed revelations and retrospective letter structure demand that readers engage in reconstructing a timeline that has been obscured by trauma and marginalization. Similarly, the movie's temporal

compression through musical montage and symbolic color coding visually reconstructs a non-linear sense of history that reflects both individual trauma and collective memory. In both mediums, anachrony becomes a tool to reclaim agency over time, challenging dominant narrative forms and illuminating the emotional realities of Black womanhood across generations.

In conclusion, both the novel and the movie employ anachrony that aligns with Genette's narrative time theory, challenging conventional linear storytelling. Within mainstream narratives, Black women are often reduced to archetypes of "victims" or "inspirational symbols." However, *The Color Purple* utilizes anachrony to convey the complex realities of Black women's experiences. In the novel, the disjointed timeline of the letters illustrates Celie's arduous journey from silence to self-assertion, with the fragmented nature of the letters symbolizing the psychological oppression she endures. Her memories are disordered, preventing her from directly confronting her trauma and leading to the suppression of her authentic self. In the 2023 movie adaptation, the temporal shifts presented in the montage, along with the strategic use of music, create a sense of temporal disjunction, emphasizing that Celie's awakening is not a sudden epiphany but rather the result of persistent resistance. The elaborate dance sequences, characterized by the contrasting fluidity and posture of Celie's body, further highlight her personal development and emancipation.

3.2 Narrative Duration in Novel and Movie

While Genette's typology of narrative duration was introduced in Chapter 2, this section provides a close reading of *The Color Purple* through specific applications of "Pause" and "Summary" in both the original novel and the 2023 movie adaptation. It demonstrates how different narrative media shape temporal perception and emotional impact. In particular, while the novel relies on textual elaboration to stretch or compress narrative time, the movie innovatively employs music as a central tool to regulate narrative duration and enhance emotional engagement

3.2.1. Narrative Duration in the Novel

In the epistolary framework of the novel, Celie frequently revisits similar circumstances through evocative language, establishing a characteristic "Pause" narrative pattern in which narrative time surpasses story time. This temporal delay not only immerses the reader in emotional experiences but also structurally underscores the persistence of emotion and the inevitability of suffering. For instance, following her abuse by her husband, Mr. _, Celie's letters explore the psychological intricacies of the violence over several pages.

"He beat me as he beats the children. Except he hardly ever beats them. He says, 'Celie, get the belt.' The children are outside the room, peeking through the cracks. It's all I can do not to cry. I make myself stiff. I tell myself, 'Celie, you are a tree.' That's how I know trees fear man" (Walker,1982, pp.78-79).

In this excerpt, although the act of violence is fleeting, Celie transforms it into an enduring mental anguish. Through the nuanced repetition of language, symbolic imagery (such as the "tree"), and emotional self-direction, Walker creates a "Pause" rhythm that ensnares both the protagonist and the reader in the stasis of trauma.

Moreover, in the narrative surrounding the "disappearance" of Celie's sister Nettie, Celie consistently expresses feelings of doubt, denial, and a persistent hope regarding death.

"I don't say anything. I think about Nettie, who is dead." (Walker,1982, p.77)

"But nothing comes. She's dead, I say." (Walker,1982, p.391)

"Nettie, I don't believe you're dead. How can you be dead if I still feel you?" (Walker,1982, p.945)

These letters, which cover only a few days in the story's timeline, expand the text's temporal experience through repeated expressions of questioning and uncertainty, effectively pressing the "pause" button. Celie's despair crystallizes into a profound sense of existential void. This narrative technique not only aligns with Genette's concept of "pause" but also underscores a fundamental contradiction inherent in the epistolary form: the text functions as both Celie's cathartic outlet and a testament to her entrapment within time.

Conversely, the novel utilizes "summary" to explore the theme of everyday survival. Summary condenses specific periods of story time into concise sentences that highlight key elements, resulting in narrative time that is significantly shorter than story time, with the

summary being notably briefer than the scene (Wang 69). For instance, when the narrative depicts Celie's transformation into an independent woman who runs a pants factory, this evolution is succinctly captured in just a few lines, thereby underscoring Genette's concept of the narrator's evaluation of event significance — where material hardship gives way to spiritual awakening (Genette 94).

In conclusion, the fragmented narrative structure inherent in the epistolary form allows Walker to skillfully manipulate narrative duration. As the narrator, Celie has the agency to expand or compress time, thereby reconstructing narrative time and emphasizing the process of individual consciousness awakening.

3.2.2. Narrative Duration in the movie

In comparison to the original novel, the 2023 movie adaptation omits the internal monologue characteristic of the epistolary format, relying instead on music as the primary medium for regulating narrative tempo rather than employing "Pause." At pivotal moments, music not only serves a narrative function but also substitutes for text, facilitating the manipulation of time and acting as an emotional catalyst.

In the novel, Celie's internal conflicts are often expressed through repetitive phrases, which create temporal delays, exemplified by her repeated pleas of "Dear God." This repetition highlights her psychological stagnation and suffering. In contrast, the movie employs music to extend time and evoke similar emotional responses. For instance, during the scene in which Celie reveals her trauma to Shug, the director features a five-minute blues duet titled *"Two Women"*. The camera gradually zooms out from a close-up of Celie and Shug's expressions, transitioning to a " *"play-within-a-play"*" on the screen, where an airplane is seen taking off. A pianist is introduced, and Celie and Shug begin to sing slowly, symbolizing the resurgence of Celie's inner self following her trauma. The lyrics "What about my wings when I fall?" poignantly express Celie's profound emotional needs and her gradual journey toward self-awareness (Bazawule, 2023). This segment harnesses the emotive power of song to encapsulate years of oppression and aspirations for the future. The repetition of lyrics and the extended melody serve to stretch time, thereby accumulating emotional weight and creating a visual and auditory "Pause."

Simultaneously, as the movie condenses extensive plot developments from the novel, it frequently accelerates the musical tempo to refine and compress the narrative. As George

Bluestone posits, "Novels allow for lengthiness, but movies must be concise" (8). The director often omits descriptive elements and events that do not lend themselves to visual representation in order to streamline the narrative and emphasize critical moments. For example, the novel contains a protracted and detailed account of Celie's three-year endeavor to establish her pants factory (Walker, 1982, pp.167-189), whereas the movie condenses this duration into a vibrant three-minute African drum dance titled *Threads of Hope*. The camera captures an aerial view of dynamic female workers engaging with colorful fabrics, while the accompanying African drum rhythm accelerates from 60 beats per minute to 120 beats per minute. The dancers' movements evolve from chaotic to synchronized, culminating in a display of heightened spirit, smiles, and individual confidence (Bazawule, 2023). In this instance, Genette's concept of "summary" is innovatively reinterpreted through synchronized visual and auditory rhythms. The progressively increasing tempo of the drums subtly signifies the passage of time and enhanced productivity, while the dancers' transition from disorder to harmony represents a shift from individual effort to collective collaboration.

In conclusion, the 2023 cinematic adaptation of *The Color Purple* effectively addresses the narrative limitations posed by the lack of an epistolary framework through the innovative use of music. The movie skillfully manipulates narrative duration to deepen the emotional resonance of its characters and condenses time to convey the plot succinctly. By employing music to influence the rhythm of the narrative, the adaptation provides a unique emotional experience and alters temporal perception, thereby enriching its narrative language and fostering a more immediate and profound emotional connection with the audience.

The original novel achieves an extended narrative duration through detailed textual elaboration, effectively prolonging emotional moments. In contrast, the 2023 movie adaptation employs music, dance, and cinematographic techniques to either extend or compress narrative time. This approach facilitates a deeper engagement with critical emotions through audiovisual elements. As movie theorist Michel Chion asserts, "Music is not just a backdrop; it can distort our perception of time, making one minute feel like ten" (Chion 89). By utilizing music-driven modifications in narrative duration, the movie highlights the oppression faced by Black women, thereby amplifying its emotional impact

on the audience.

3.3 Narrative Frequency in Novel and Movie

Genette's theory of narrative frequency delineates the relationship between the frequency of events and their narrative representation, categorizing them into three distinct types: singular narration (1N/1S), repetitive narration (nN/1S), and iterative narration (1N/nS) (Genette 114-116). In Alice Walker's original novel, *The Color Purple*, the use of textual repetition enhances the emotional impact of pivotal moments. Similarly, the 2023 movie adaptation preserves this narrative intent by transforming textual repetition into recurring musical motifs, using audiovisual language to evoke emotional depth and sustain narrative continuity across media.

3.3.1 Narrative Frequency in the Novel

The novel employs an epistolary format, in which repetition within the text establishes a distinctive pattern of narrative frequency. A prominent example of this repetitive narration (nN/1S) is found in Celie's recurring prayers to God. Each of the first 51 letters begins with the phrase "Dear God" (8-51), which functions as a fixed expression similar to a religious ritual, thereby constituting a form of repetitive narration. Although the content of each letter varies, the persistent invocation of this phrase anchors Celie's traumatic experiences within a cyclical emotional framework of oppression. The repetition of "Dear God" not only signifies a reliance on faith but also serves as a form of protest against silence, indicating that Celie is trapped in a recurring narrative of trauma.

Furthermore, the novel repeatedly invokes the color purple, transforming a singular event into a recurring symbolic motif. In a pivotal conversation, Shug tells Celie: "I think it pisses God off if you walk by the color purple in a field somewhere and don't notice it" (Walker, 1982, p. 203). This dialogue is revisited in subsequent letters, exemplifying iterative narration (1N/nS), where a singular narrative encapsulates multiple events. Through this textual repetition, Walker elevates color purple from a mere color to a metaphor representing the awakening of Black women. The amplification of narrative frequency through repetition not only enriches the themes of the novel but also enhances its universal relevance. In the preface, Walker asserts, the Spirit: Without whose assistance,

neither this book nor I would have been written (Walker, 1982, p7). This embodies the central theme of the novel, encapsulating Celie's journey of self-discovery and awakening while advocating for women's liberation.

3.3.2 Narrative Frequency in the Movie

The 2023 movie adaptation is limited by the linear nature of the movie medium, which prevents a direct replication of the novel's technique of textual repetition. However, the movie reconstructs narrative frequency through a multimodal strategy centered on music, performance, and visual motifs. These elements serve as a form of "repetitive narration" (nN/1S), wherein multiple narrative instances are condensed into recurring symbolic or musical forms.

One of the most prominent examples is the cyclical appearance of the theme song "*I'm Here*". It is performed at four distinct points in the movie, each aligning with a milestone in Celie's journey—from her childhood isolation and domestic abuse to her eventual empowerment and reconciliation with her sister (Bazawule, 2023). Each reprise of the song functions as a narrative anchor, compressing multiple experiences into a singular musical expression. The song thus becomes a narrative refrain, using repetition not merely for emphasis, but as a structural device that charts Celie's psychological and emotional transformation.

Additionally, the movie reflects the novel's textual frequency through the repetition of lyrics. For example, in Shug's solo "Too Beautiful for Words," the phrase "You're too beautiful for words" is repeated five times (Bazawule, 2023), echoing the scattered moments in the novel where Shug affirms Celie's self-worth (Walker, 1982, p. 156). In this instance, the movie condenses a series of distinct affirmations into a single, emotionally impactful scene, reinforcing Celie's developing sense of identity. The auditory aspect of repetition—especially through Shug's melodic intonation—introduces an emotional depth that text alone cannot convey. This technique of "repetitive narration" condenses the novel's scattered descriptions into a concentrated emotional expression, while the emotional weight of the music amplifies the impact of this repetition. As movie scholar Kassabian suggests, "The repetition of musical motifs can transcend the limitations of space and time, establishing narrative connections in the viewer's subconscious, thereby replacing text in deepening the theme" (Kassabian 72).

Beyond lyrics and theme songs, the movie further reflects narrative frequency through rhythmic and choreographic patterns. The novel employs textual repetition to reveal the repressed collective memory of Black women, while the movie expresses the fluidity of this memory through musical and bodily performance. A key instance of this is the repeated incorporation of African drum rhythms during the factory dance scene in "*Threads of Hope*" which condenses the novel's extended portrayal of Celie's entrepreneurship into a dynamic, communal performance (Bazawule, 2023). The recurrence of percussive elements not only symbolizes continuity and heritage in the labor of Black women but also resonates with the "call and response" tradition intrinsic to African diasporic culture, where repetition fosters a sense of shared identity and resilience (Gates, 1988, p. 78).

Moreover, the spatial arrangement of performances — such as the positioning of characters during musical sequences — creates layers of repetition and variation. In the dinner scene where Celie finally stands up to Mr. _, the staging and musical reprise of *"I'm Here"* serve as both a culmination and a recall. The choreography, music, and dialogue collaborate to form a composite narrative unit that encapsulates previous iterations of Celie's silent endurance and transforms them into a moment of vocal empowerment.

In this sense, the movie transcends individual storytelling, elevating Celie's personal narrative to a broader collective epic. The rhythmic recurrence of musical and visual motifs reflects not only individual transformation but the generational legacies of resistance, care, and creativity among Black women. These artistic choices underscore the cultural enrichment that emerges from cross-media adaptation.

In summary, although the movie cannot employ epistolary or discursive repetition in the same way as the novel, it compensates through a carefully constructed system of musical, lyrical, and visual recurrence. This multimodal repetition functions not only as a structural narrative technique but also as a powerful vehicle for emotional and thematic expression, effectively translating Genette's concept of narrative frequency into the audiovisual language of cinema. The emotional resonance originally achieved through textual repetition is reinterpreted within a cyclical and layered audiovisual framework, thus preserving the novel's central themes while introducing new artistic dimensions. This transformation highlights the unique narrative power of music and imagery, demonstrating

how movie can employ musical and visual repetition to convey thematic depth comparable to literature.

3.4 Conclusion

This chapter illustrates that Gérard Genette's theory of narrative time serves as a significant analytical framework for examining the temporal transformations between the original novel of *The Color Purple* and its 2023 musical movie adaptation. Through a meticulous analysis of the dimensions of order, duration, and frequency, this study elucidates not only the reconfiguration of temporal structures across different media but also how these alterations influence the emotional, ideological, and aesthetic resonance of the narrative. The novel's fragmented epistolary format engenders a nonlinear temporality characterized by analepsis and prolepsis, reflecting Celie's psychological disorientation and the historical marginalization of Black women. These disruptions in narrative order critique patriarchal and colonial linearity, reclaiming memory as a nonlinear and subjective domain.

Conversely, while the movie adaptation presents a more linear surface structure, it does not abandon this resistance. Instead, it recontextualizes temporal manipulation through audiovisual techniques — employing montage, cross-cutting, choreography, and color symbolism to evoke emotional time rather than mere chronological time. Emotional climaxes are often suspended within musical sequences that serve as temporal "pauses," encouraging viewers to engage with their feelings rather than follow a linear progression. In terms of duration, the novel's language extends pivotal moments through internal reflection and detailed narration. In contrast, the movie employs musical recurrence and visual rhythm to achieve similar effects, transitioning from introspective narration to embodied expression. The incorporation of looping choreographies and refrains in significant scenes, such as reunions or traumatic recollections, visually simulates temporal intensification.

Regarding frequency, repetition operates both structurally and thematically. In the novel, iterative narration reinforces themes of abuse and resistance through Celie's letters. The movie, however, reconceptualizes repetition through recurring visual metaphors and

musical leitmotifs, transforming isolated trauma into collective remembrance. This aesthetic approach enables the movie to contextualize personal suffering within a broader cultural history. Importantly, this chapter argues that the 2023 adaptation transcends a mere translation of temporal structure from text to screen; it recontextualizes time as a site of feminist and racial rearticulation. Time is portrayed not as a neutral or mechanical construct but as an affective, political, and aesthetic phenomenon. The movie's manipulation of time emerges as a form of cultural critique, challenging prevailing narratives of progress and healing by highlighting cyclical suffering, interrupted joy, and communal resilience.

In this way, the movie establishes a unique aesthetic and critical language, rooted not in literary introspection but in multisensory performance. It reframes Celie's narrative journey through the lens of Black expressive culture, which includes gospel, blues, and dance, thereby transforming individual experiences into collective, embodied storytelling. Ultimately, this case study highlights that narrative time — far from being a passive chronological framework — serves as a fundamental mode of meaning-making. The adaptation of *The Color Purple* presents a compelling model for how cross-media storytelling can preserve thematic richness while innovating formal strategies.

Chapter Four Narrative Voice in Novel and Movie

To analyze the transformation of narrative voice from Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* to its 2023 movie adaptation, this chapter draws on Gérard Genette's distinction between narrative levels and narrator types, as introduced in *Narrative Discourse* (1980). Rather than reiterating theoretical definitions, this section focuses on the practical application of these concepts to highlight the differences between the novel's epistolary structure and the movie's audiovisual narration.

The novel constructs its narrative voice primarily through a homodiegetic narrator—Celie—whose story unfolds through a series of personal letters. This format creates layered narrative levels, shifting from Celie's letters to God, to her sister Nettie's accounts from Africa, and finally to Celie's retrospective reflections, illustrating her emotional growth and evolving self-awareness (Walker, 1982). In contrast, the movie reinterprets these layers using cinematic techniques. Musical expression, voiceovers, and symbolic visuals—such as the "play-within-a-play" scenes—serve as heterodiegetic narrative tools that provide an externalized yet emotionally resonant perspective (Bazawule, 2023). These differences not only reflect the constraints and affordances of each medium but also reveal how narrative authority and audience engagement are restructured through shifts in narrative voice.

4.1 Transformations of Narrative Voice in the Novel and Movie

4.1.1 Transformations of Narrative Voice in the Novel

In Alice Walker's novel, *The Color Purple*, the narrative is structured in an epistolary format that creates a multifaceted layering of narrative levels, enabling a nuanced representation of female subjectivity and psychological transformation. The initial 51 letters written by Celie begin with the salutation "Dear God," placing them within the "extradiegetic" narrative level, as the narrator is addressing a divine presence rather than another character within the story world (Walker, 1982, pp. 8-51). This positioning

indicates a dialogue with an authority that transcends the confines of the narrative world. And this narrative device simultaneously emphasizes Celie's spiritual isolation and her search for moral guidance in a world marked by gendered and racial violence. For instance, in the first letter, Celie writes, "He never had a kind word to say to me," revealing her powerlessness and the silence forced upon her by an abusive father figure (Walker, 1982, p. 1).

The shift in narrative level occurs in letter 52. Beginning with the 52nd letter, the correspondence from Nettie introduces the "intradiegetic" narrative level, which focuses on her experiences in Africa, thereby establishing a parallel temporal and spatial context to Celie's own story (Walker, 1982, p.110). Through her letters, Nettie not only offers a diasporic counterpoint to Celie's rural American life but also expands the scope of the novel's thematic concerns, including colonialism, missionary education, and African identity. Her observation—"The people here are not what I expected. They are proud and full of grace"—foregrounds a narrative parallelism that complicates and enriches Celie's trajectory (Walker, 1982, p. 120).

As Celie and Nettie's correspondence continues, a metadiegetic level emerges, particularly as Celie reflects on her past and contemplates her future. This is evident in letter 73, when Celie writes: "I'm pore, I'm black, I may be ugly and can't cook… But I'm here." This moment of introspective defiance encapsulates her psychological evolution from silence to self-affirmation (Walker, 1982, p. 187). Her engagement with her own memories and with Nettie's accounts catalyzes a re-evaluation of her identity, situating her voice within a layered, recursive narrative frame. As Lanser (1981) argues, such embedded narration allows marginalized voices to contest dominant narrative structures and claim narrative authority through introspection and recollection.

Moreover, this layered narrative structure necessitates active participation from the reader, who must synthesize fragmented temporalities and multiple narrative perspectives. This aligns with feminist narrative theorists such as Susan Stanford Friedman (1998), who suggest that nonlinear, dialogic storytelling is especially effective in representing the multiplicity of women's experiences across race, geography, and history. The interplay between Celie's letters, Nettie's epistles, and Celie's later self-reflective writing ultimately mirrors her transformation from a voiceless victim to a narrating subject capable of

articulating her desires, ethics, and worldview.

Thus, the epistolary form in *The Color Purple* is not merely a formal choice but a vehicle for layered narration that thematically enacts Celie's emancipation. As Tucker (1988) observes, Walker's use of narrative levels serves as "an emergent structure" through which the protagonist discovers her capacity to narrate her own life and challenge hegemonic discourses of race, gender, and power.

4.1.2 Transformations of Narrative Voice in the Novel and Movie

In contrast to the layered epistolary structure of Alice Walker's novel, the 2023 musical movie adaptation of *The Color Purple*, directed by Blitz Bazawule, reconfigures narrative levels through visual, auditory, and spatial techniques unique to cinematic storytelling. While the movie adaptation is limited by the inherent characteristics of audiovisual media, which prevent a direct replication of the letter-based nested structure found in the novel, the movie reconstructs narrative temporality through visual layers, performative and symbolic strategies that propel the plot forward, effectively illustrating Celie's personal development and awakening and the multi-levelled structure of the original text.

The movie opens with a depiction of Celie's early years in rural Georgia (Bazawule, 2023). The visual mise-en-scène — muted color palette, overcast lighting, and static camerawork — immediately establishes an extradiegetic perspective, where the camera functions as an external observer narrating Celie's world from an omniscient vantage point. The house she lives in is portrayed as cramped and shadowy, amplifying the emotional desolation and repression that defines her early life. These choices align with Genette's (1980) concept of the extradiegetic narrator, one who operates outside the primary diegetic space to establish the story's framework.

As the narrative progresses, the intradiegetic level is constructed through emotionally embedded musical performances that reveal character subjectivity. For example, during Shug's musical performance of "*Too Beautiful for Words*", the camera focuses on Celie's facial expressions, her silent tears, and the warm, golden lighting that bathes the scene, contrasting sharply with earlier gloom (Bazawule, 2023). This shift not only situates the

viewer within Celie's emotional realm but also parallels the narrative shift in the novel, wherein Celie commences to experience self-recognition through interpersonal connection. The performance, therefore, becomes an intradiegetic moment in which narration emerges from within the story world, conveyed through music rather than text. This phenomenon is a hallmark of cinematic adaptation, as described by Chatman (1980), who emphasizes that movie "shows" while literature "tells."

A particularly innovative technique employed by Bazawule is the "play-within-a-play" or metadiegetic insertion, notably during the scene where Celie and Shug watch a silent movie that features an airplane flying into the sky. The moment is imbued with metaphorical resonance: as the characters gaze at the screen, the audience is transported into Celie's interior fantasy of escape and liberation. The airplane becomes a metadiegetic symbol of transcendence, mirroring the moment in the novel when Celie imagines a life beyond Mr. _'s control (Walker, 1982, p. 189). This layered viewing experience, where the characters observe a representation within the story world, enacts Genette's (1980) concept of narrative embedding, allowing viewers to access the protagonist's dreams through cinematic symbolism.

Furthermore, Bazawule frequently utilizes montage and color transitions to symbolize narrative temporality and psychological evolution. In one sequence, Celie's growing independence is depicted through a series of intercut scenes—sewing pants, laughing with Shug, walking confidently—which represent a nonlinear narrative layer. This nonlinear narrative layer echoes the metadiegetic structure of memory and reflection in the novel. As Bordwell (1985) observes, this "parametric narration" in movie offers a structural analogy to literary techniques of internal focalization and temporal fragmentation.

While this movie necessarily simplifies some of the novel's narrative complexity, particularly the dual narrators and extended correspondences, it compensates by creating an immersive, multi-sensory experience that translates interior voice into visual and musical form. By reinterpreting narrative levels through mise-en-scène, performance, and symbolic motifs, the movie adaptation maintains fidelity to the spirit of the original text while demonstrating the affordances of cinematic language.

4.2 Narrator in the Novel and Movie

4.2.1 Narrator in the Novel

Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* employs a predominantly homodiegetic narrator, with Celie recounting her life through a series of deeply personal letters. As the central narrative voice, Celie occupies a dual role: both as the protagonist and as the chronicler of her own experiences. Her narration is presented in a first-person epistolary form, which foregrounds the subjectivity of her perspective and positions the reader as an intimate witness to her psychological and emotional evolution. This homodiegetic narration aligns with Genette's (1980) definition, wherein the narrator is also a character within the story world, and thus recounts events in which she directly participates (p. 245).

Due to her limited education and her oppressed social status as a poor African American girl in the American South in the early 20th century, Celie's narrative voice is characterized by non-standard syntax, phonetic spelling, and dialectal variety. The novel begins, for instance, with the words, "You better never tell anybody but God." It would kill your mother. (Walker, 1982, p. 3). In addition to authenticating Celie's speech, the lack of punctuation and grammatical structure serves as a narrative device that reflects her lack of agency and voice. According to Shi (1986), Celie's language style highlights how race, gender, and class intertwine to shape narrative identity and is a performative portrayal of her social marginalization (p. 16).

The result is what Booth terms "unreliable narration," where the narrator's limited knowledge and emotional bias invite readers to interpret and sometimes question the narrated events (Booth, 1983, p. 150). This unreliability, however, does not undermine the narrative's authenticity; rather, it deepens the reader's engagement with Celie's trauma and fosters a participatory role in reconstructing her truth. For instance, when Celie writes about Mister's abuse, the fragmented language—"He beat me today cause he say I winked at a boy in church" (Walker, 1982, p. 6)—simultaneously conveys physical violence and her internalized guilt, leaving much to be inferred by the reader. Such moments highlight the power dynamics embedded within both the story world and the narrative structure

itself.

Nettie's letters, which enter the narrative from letter 52 onward, introduce a second homodiegetic narrator and a parallel narrative strand situated in a geographically and culturally distinct context — Africa. Nettie's voice is markedly more articulate and grammatically correct, reflecting her formal education and missionary environment: "The people here are so beautiful. Their skin glows in the sun, and their laughter is like music" (Walker, 1982, p. 123). Her narrative provides historical and cultural context that broadens the thematic scope of the novel to include issues of colonialism, diaspora, and transnational black identity (Hall, 1992).

However, both Celie and Nettie are limited by their internal focalization, offering insights filtered solely through their perceptions. This limitation becomes evident in the portrayal of complex characters like Shug Avery. Shug's character, while pivotal to Celie's personal awakening, is revealed exclusively through Celie's perspective, which constrains a multifaceted understanding of Shug's motivations and development. For example, readers learn of Shug's vulnerability and defiance not through direct narration but through Celie's emotional response: "She say, Celie, tell the truth, have you ever felt that way bout Albert? I say, Naw, only when he beat me" (Walker, 1982, p. 114). The indirect nature of this character construction underscores the subjective limitations inherent in homodiegetic narration.

Ultimately, the novel's dual homodiegetic voices allow for a richly textured but deliberately partial view of the narrative world. Their contrasting linguistic styles, narrative reliability, and epistemological boundaries reflect Walker's broader concern with the fragmentation of black female identity and the politics of self-representation. The epistolary form thus becomes both a narrative structure and a symbolic medium for reclamation—of voice, agency, and memory.

4.2.2 Narrator in the Movie

In the 2023 musical movie adaptation of *The Color Purple*, directed by Blitz Bazawule, the narrative structure undergoes a significant transformation from the epistolary and homodiegetic form of the novel to a visually driven, heterodiegetic mode of

storytelling. Unlike the novel, which relies on Celie's first-person narration through letters, the movie presents a third-person narrative voice that is not situated within the diegetic world of the characters. This aligns with Genette's definition of the heterodiegetic narrator—a narrator who exists outside the story world and does not participate in the narrated events (1980).

Though the movie maintains a consistent emotional alignment with Celie's perspective, it deploys cinematic techniques that simulate an omniscient viewpoint. For example, in the pivotal scene where Celie and Shug discover Nettie's hidden letters, Bazawule utilises a combination of close-up and wide-angle shots to shift narrative focus. The camera begins with a close-up of Celie's trembling hands as she touches the envelopes, then transitions to a wide shot that envelops both characters in dim, reverent lighting. At the same time, a voiceover reads the contents of the letter aloud. This voiceover, unanchored to either character's diegetic voice, exemplifies the function of a heterodiegetic narrator, guiding the viewer's understanding from an external vantage point (Bazawule, 2023).

This narratorial shift reflects what Chatman refers to as the "cinematic narrator," an abstract construction created through framing, editing, and sound design, which serves a role analogous to that of the literary narrator in prose fiction (Chatman, 1990, p. 128). In particular, the use of voiceover narration and symbolic visual composition throughout the movie provides commentary and emotional modulation that supplements the protagonist's inner world, which cannot be directly accessed as in the novel's first-person letters.

Moreover, Bazawule expands the narratorial framework by incorporating diegetic musical performances that serve as both expressive tools and indirect narrators. A striking example occurs during Shug Avery's performance of "*Too Beautiful for Words*". The scene oscillates between a stage performance and an intimate focus on Celie's rapt expression, using soft lighting and tight framing to visualize Celie's emotional awakening. Shug's performance thus functions narratively, not just as entertainment, but as a moment of revelation, reinforcing her role as a secondary diegetic narrator who facilitates Celie's self-realization (Bazawule, 2023). This corresponds with Naremore's argument that characters in musical movies often assume narrative authority through lyrical performance, collapsing the boundary between action and narration (Naremore, 1990, p. 19).

Further, Shug's moral and emotional influence on Celie resonates with Wayne Booth's concept of the "implied author"—an organizing consciousness behind the narrative that guides ethical interpretation (Booth, 1983, p. 74). Shug's interventions—such as urging Celie to read the letters or helping her reclaim her name—embody the movie's ethical orientation toward female solidarity, resistance, and emotional liberation.

Overall, the 2023 movie adaptation does not replicate the novel's narratorial intimacy but reimagines it through a hybrid narrational structure that combines heterodiegetic control with focalized empathy. By integrating cinematographic, musical, and editorial techniques, the movie crafts a layered narrative voice that is simultaneously external and emotionally embedded, enhancing viewer engagement with Celie's journey of empowerment.

4.3 Conclusion

The comparative analysis of narrative voice in Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* and its 2023 movie adaptation reveals not only a formal transformation in narrative strategy but also a significant evolution in the representation of female subjectivity, memory, and empowerment across different media. In the original novel, Walker employs an epistolary homodiegetic voice, primarily through the characters of Celie and later Nettie, which establishes a deeply personal, layered, and introspective narrative framework. These letters serve not merely to document events but also to facilitate the process of self-reclamation. The narrative's multiple levels—extradiegetic, intradiegetic, and metadiegetic—reflect Celie's progression from silence to voice and from object to narrating subject. This fragmentation of voice and temporality necessitates active engagement from the reader, positioning them as co-creators of meaning and challenging prevailing linear and patriarchal storytelling conventions.

In contrast, the 2023 musical movie adaptation reconfigures narrative voice through the unique visual and auditory capabilities of cinema. Lacking direct access to first-person textual narration, the movie employs heterodiegetic techniques—such as voiceovers, musical performances, symbolic mise-en-scène, and cinematic framing—to evoke the emotional intimacy found in the novel. While this approach simplifies the narrative

complexity of the original text, it fosters an immediacy of affect and a shared engagement among viewers that is distinctly cinematic. The emotional interiority of characters is translated into visual symbolism, and narration becomes performative, embodied through music, dance, and spatial arrangement. Characters like Shug not only propel the plot but also serve as secondary narrators, with their songs and gestures carrying significant ethical and transformative implications.

These shifts are not merely technical; they signify a substantial change in narrative agency and audience reception. In the novel, the voice emerges from within—quietly, painfully, and in fragments—reflecting the lived experiences of Black women who are silenced by intersecting systems of race, gender, and class. Conversely, in the movie, the voice is externalized, collectivized, and aestheticized, resonating with the tradition of Black expressive culture and creating opportunities for communal witnessing and public emotional engagement. The transition from text to screen, from letter to song, represents not a diminishment but a reconfiguration of feminist narration, one that emphasizes visibility, embodiment, and solidarity.

Ultimately, the interplay between homodiegetic introspection and heterodiegetic orchestration in both versions of *The Color Purple* highlights the adaptive potential of narrative voice. Whether expressed through personal testimony or audiovisual spectacle, Celie's voice—fragmented, reconstructed, and amplified—serves as the essential conduit through which the story's feminist and emancipatory ethos is powerfully sustained.

Chapter Five Narrative Situation in Novel and Movie

While earlier chapters have explored the identity of the storyteller and the organization of time within narratives, an equally significant inquiry remains: from which perspective does the narrative unfold, and how does this positioning influence the audience's ability to perceive, experience, and understand the story? This chapter aims to address this inquiry by engaging with the concept of narrative situation, which shifts analytical focus from the identity of the narrator to the structural dynamics among the narrator, characters, and audience.

In contrast to narrative voice, which emphasizes the origin and level of narration, narrative situation examines the construction, maintenance, and fluid transfer of perspective within a narrative. This concept is especially relevant in the context of cross-media adaptations, where perspective can be spatially organized, collectivized, or dispersed in ways that are not possible in print-based storytelling. As a result, narrative situation emerges not merely as a narrative device but as a cultural mechanism that influences visibility, interiority, and power dynamics.

To analyze the reconfiguration of the narrative situation in both *The Color Purple* and its 2023 musical movie adaptation, this chapter employs Franz K. Stanzel's typology, which categorizes narrative modes into three distinct types: Authorial, characterized by an omniscient narrator who exists outside the narrative and guides interpretation; Figural, which restricts perception to the limited viewpoint of a character; and Neutral, where events unfold without overt narrative intervention or commentary (Stanzel, 1984).

These categories provide a valuable framework for understanding how both the novel and the movie navigate narrative authority, modulate audience alignment, and portray Black female subjectivity across diverse formal and ideological contexts. By applying Stanzel's model, this chapter examines how shifts in narrative situation function not only as aesthetic strategies but also as tools of cultural critique, highlighting how the act of storytelling is inherently intertwined with structures of vision, voice, and power.

5.1 Narrative Situation Shifts in the Novel

While the novel primarily utilizes the correspondence between Celie and Nettie, along with Celie's prayers to God, as its main narrative framework, Walker skillfully incorporates instances of figural narrative situations through the occasional narrative interventions of secondary characters. This technique transcends the limitations of a singular perspective, which allows the novel to explore the inner lives of other characters, broaden its thematic scope, and enhance the complexity of narrative authority.

A compelling example occurs during the episode involving Harpo and Sofia's marriage. When Harpo seeks advice from Mr. _ about his inability to control Sofia, the narrative momentarily shifts from Celie's figural perspective to an authorial narrative situation. The narrator presents Harpo's dialogue and internal experience directly, without Celie's mediating consciousness. The exchange illustrates this shift: "Why am I not good enough?" Harpo inquires of Mr. _. Mr. __responds, "Your mammy." Harpo then asks, "What's wrong with my mammy?" to which Mr. _ replies, "Somebody killed her" (Walker, 1982, p.95). The scene then transitions into a vivid description of Harpo's dream, where he envisions his mother being chased across a field—an episode narrated with a psychological depth and visual detail that suggests an omniscient, external point of view.

This narrative transitions from Celie's subjective viewpoint, indicative of a figural narrative situation, to an authorial narrative perspective, allowing the narrator to provide an omniscient view of Harpo's emotional turmoil and the oppression he endures. This shift underscores Walker's critical examination of the challenges faced by men within a patriarchal framework. This shift in narrative situation functions not merely as a stylistic device but as a means of illustrating the internalization of patriarchal expectations by male characters. Harpo's struggle with masculinity—caught between social norms and his emotional vulnerability—is made visible through this authorial intervention. Walker does not limit her feminist critique to female oppression but also interrogates how patriarchy deforms male identity and emotional expression. The brief omniscient narration thus reinforces Walker's broader thematic concern with systemic gender oppression, offering a multidimensional portrayal of suffering that transcends gender binaries.

Consequently, although *The Color Purple* remains anchored in Celie's subjective perspective and epistolary figural situation, Walker fluidly shifts among narrative positions to deepen character development and thematic resonance. Through embedded dialogues, psychological renderings, and occasional authorial commentary, she expands the narrative's scope while retaining Celie's emotional centrality. This technique exemplifies what Stanzel (1984) terms the "interplay of narrative situations," where a dominant figural perspective coexists with momentary incursions of authorial narration to produce a more textured and ethically nuanced storytelling mode.

5.2 Narrative Situation Shifts in the Movie

The 2023 movie adaptation of *The Color Purple*, directed by Blitz Bazawule, employs a dynamic interplay of neutral, figural, and authorial narrative perspectives by means of audiovisual strategies such as music, choreography, mise-en-scène, and voice-over. These multimodal techniques enable the movie to externalize the characters' psychological depth and convey a sense of collective emotional experience, thereby compensating for the introspective and internally focalized nature of the novel's epistolary form.

One salient example is the Memphis pants-making sequence, where music and dance mark a transformative narrative shift. In this scene, where Celie operates a pants-making business in Memphis, a vibrant musical and dance sequence is introduced. This sequence begins with a neutral narrative situation, depicting the female workers silently engaged in the mechanical and repetitive task of cutting fabric (Bazawule, 2023). As rhythmic African drums begin to play, the mise-en-scène gradually transitions into a choreographed celebration(Bazawule, 2023). The scene transitions to an expansive overhead shot, showcasing the workers rising and dancing while holding flowing purple fabric that resembles waves, and this overhead camera captures a sea of purple fabric flowing like waves, visually symbolizing liberation and creativity. At this point, Celie, Shug, and Sofia initiate solo performances, which are soon joined by the ensemble in a chorus singing, "Look who is wearing pants now!" (Bazawule, 2023). As the dance unfolds, the camera rises from a close-up of Celie's shoes to her face, revealing the tears in her eyes and her broad smile. This transition signifies a shift from the neutral narrative situation of the labor

scene to a figural narrative situation, reflecting Celie's newfound autonomy and joy. It subsequently evolves into an authorial narrative situation through the collective dance, embodying what Stanzel describes as an omniscient, evaluative perspective. The collective performance does not merely entertain; it expresses a shared narrative of economic independence and communal empowerment among Black women, reinforcing the feminist ethos of the story. This elevates the themes of individual economic independence and the collective awakening of Black women.

In a contrasting scene following Celie's departure, Mr.'s descent into chaos is portrayed through a neutral narrative lens characterized by excessive drinking and the destruction of furniture. The camera captures his disordered behavior in a detached manner (Bazawule, 2023). However, upon realizing the consequences of his actions, as he lies on the scorched earth, his lamentations are interwoven with voice-over narration stating, "Dear God, I will do right" (Bazawule, 2023). This moment aligns with Chatman's notion of the "implied author," wherein the narrative's moral stance becomes manifest through formal techniques rather than direct commentary. The inclusion of Celie's voice in the voice-over serves as an authorial intervention, directly critiquing Mr.'s moral failings. This element disrupts the illusion of neutrality, compelling the audience to confront the implied author's moral assessment of his character.

Through these examples, the 2023 adaptation exemplifies a dynamic orchestration of narrative situations. By integrating diegetic musical performance, symbolic cinematography, and strategic voice-over, the movie skillfully shifts from neutral to figural and authorial narrative perspective. In doing so, it modulates narrative distance and subjectivity, enhancing emotional expressivity while preserving the story's thematic core: the journey from oppression to empowerment—not only for Celie, but also for a broader collective of historically silenced voices.

5.3 Conclusion

The comparative analysis of narrative situations in Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* and its 2023 movie adaptation reveals how each medium skillfully reconfigures point of view to enhance character development, deepen thematic exploration, and amplify

historically marginalized voices. The novel primarily utilizes Celie's figural, epistolary perspective; however, Walker frequently disrupts this interiority through authorial shifts, providing omniscient access to male characters such as Harpo and illuminating the gendered contradictions inherent in patriarchy from multiple viewpoints. These intermittent transitions not only complicate narrative authority but also expand the feminist dimensions of the text, demonstrating that oppression is intersectional and that emotional suffering transcends gender binaries.

Conversely, the 2023 movie leverages the multimodal capabilities of cinema to create a fluid and expressive orchestration of narrative situations. By integrating neutral cinematography, figural close-ups, and authorial voice-over with visual spectacle, the movie externalizes inner experiences and collective trauma through visual rhythm, performance, and symbolic mise-en-scène. For instance, scenes such as the pants-making musical number and Mr._'s breakdown exemplify how camera movement, musical framing, and vocal layering can shift the narrative stance from observation to embodiment to moral judgment. These transitions are not merely stylistic; they cultivate an affective and ethical alignment between the audience and the feminist ethos of the narrative.

In both media, the interplay of figural, authorial, and neutral perspectives exemplifies what Stanzel describes as a dynamic "interchange of narrative situations." However, while the novel employs textual layering and psychological depth to convey this fluidity, the movie translates it into aesthetic transitions and multisensory cues, inviting viewers to engage emotionally with Celie's experience rather than merely interpret it. Thus, the narrative situation functions as both a storytelling strategy and a cultural lens, mediating the distribution of narrative power and delivering social critique.

Ultimately, the evolution of the narrative situation in both iterations of *The Color Purple* underscores the story's adaptive resilience and critical significance. Whether conveyed through fragmented letters or choreographed tableaux, shifts in narrative perspective serve as formal expressions of liberation, empathy, and communal recognition —key tenets of Black feminist storytelling. These shifts empower not only Celie but also a broader network of marginalized characters, allowing their voices to resonate across various forms, mediums, and audiences.

Chapter Six Conclusions

This study conducts a comparative analysis of the original novel *The Color Purple* and its 2023 movie adaptation, systematically exploring cross-media narrative discourse through three dimensions: narrative time, narrative voice, and narrative situation. The analysis primarily employs Gérard Genette's theories of narrative time and voice, supplemented by Franz K. Stanzel's typology of narrative situations. The findings indicate that, although the two media utilize distinct narrative strategies, they maintain a strong intertextual resonance that enriches both forms, demonstrating the dynamic negotiation and creative transformation that occurs in the adaptation of literature into movie.

In terms of narrative time, the novel employs an epistolary format that creates a fragmented temporal structure, reflecting Celie's trauma, growth, and awakening in a nonlinear manner. This fragmentation facilitates a personalized and internalized approach to historical narration. In contrast, the movie utilizes visual montage, color symbolism, and musical interludes to dynamically expand and compress time, presenting Celie's life journey with heightened emotional intensity. The movie translates Gérard Genette's concepts of order, duration, and frequency into cinematic language through its use of visual montage, symbolic colors, and musical sequences. These techniques allow for a nuanced manipulation of narrative time, enhancing the story's emotional immediacy and accessibility. Ultimately, they enable the compression and expansion of narrative time in ways that amplify emotional resonance and engagement.

The novel primarily conveys its narrative through the first-person letters of Celie and Nettie, establishing a homodiegetic narrative structure. This fragmented and non-authoritative voice reflects the cultural reality of Black women's historical deprivation of narrative agency. In contrast, the 2023 movie enhances this subjective voice through heterodiegetic narration, choral performances, and voiceovers, making Celie's journey toward selfhood both more tangible and collective. This shift underscores the transition of Black women from silence to collective expression.

Concerning the narrative situation, the novel is predominantly character-bound; however, it occasionally shifts into an authorial mode through omniscient intrusions and

the portrayal of other characters' experiences. In contrast, the movie utilizes musical numbers, audiovisual language, and cinematographic techniques to create seamless transitions between neutral, character-bound, and authorial modes of narration. These dynamic shifts enrich the narrative layers and enhance emotional resonance. This flexible movement between narrative situations not only heightens the structural tension of the adaptation but also facilitates a multifaceted reinterpretation of the novel's central themes.

Overall, the 2023 movie adaptation of *The Color Purple* does not merely strive for textual fidelity; rather, it honors the thematic integrity of the original while reinterpreting its meaning through medium-specific innovations. The reconfiguration of narrative time, the orchestration of narrative voices, and the transformation of narrative situations imbue the adaptation with its own aesthetic and critical language. These strategies underscore the movie's contemporary relevance in cultural critique, gender discourse, and multimodal storytelling. This cross-media narrative practice thus provides a compelling framework for understanding the adaptive potential of literature in cinematic form and contributes to ongoing discussions in adaptation studies and narratology.

The theoretical frameworks employed — particularly the classical narratological models developed by Genette and Stanzel—are foundational for analyzing the cross-media transformation of narrative. However, the unique audiovisual affordances of cinema reveal certain limitations in applying traditional narratology to movie. Future research may benefit from integrating perspectives from postclassical narratology, which emphasize audience engagement, embodiment, and medium specificity. Furthermore, while this study adopts a primarily text-centered analytical approach, it lacks empirical insight into audience reception. For example, how different demographic or cultural groups interpret the movie's musical sequences or narrative voice remains an open question. Future studies could incorporate audience surveys or cross-cultural comparative research to enhance our understanding of how narrative adaptations function across various interpretive communities.

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Acknowledgements

This section has been delayed for quite some time; I struggled to articulate my thoughts and express my gratitude adequately. My words feel insufficient and weak, failing to convey the depth of my emotions.

First and foremost, I would like to express my heartfelt gratitude to my supervisor, Professor Li Cheng. Despite my procrastination and lack of confidence in literary studies, she never gave up on me. Her patience, insight, and gentle encouragement guided me through this thesis, helping me complete it step by step. I am especially thankful for her course on Sino-Western Philosophy, which I took during my junior year; it remains my favorite class in the English program. While I may never fully grasp the complexities of Confucianism, Taoism, Mohism, Legalism, or the philosophies of Plato, Aristotle, Bacon, Descartes, Kant, and Hegel, I often find myself revisiting her words and reflecting on the wisdom they imparted. Professor Li's mentorship has left an enduring impact on me—not only in my academic progress but also in the way I think and perceive the world. As I reflect on my journey, I recognize how I have gradually evolved: from a hesitant student to someone who has read countless Chinese characters through English texts, and from there, slowly built my own proficiency in English literacy.

I would like to express my sincere appreciation to all the teachers at the School of Foreign Languages. Their instruction and encouragement, both inside and outside the classroom, have laid the foundation for everything I have achieved over the past four years. I am grateful to every professor who challenged me to think critically, read broadly, and express myself with precision.

My deepest gratitude goes to the Student Affairs Office, whose staff supported me during challenging times throughout my illness. I would like to extend special thanks to Wanqi, Zhiyi, and Yunfan, whose presence provided comfort during moments of sudden health crises, and to Feifei, who accompanied me through late-night medical examinations. I am thankful to everyone who assisted in my recovery and accompanied me to follow-up appointments. Your kindness will always be remembered.

I owe tremendous gratitude to my parents, who supported me throughout these four years with unwavering care. Whether I was unwell or overwhelmed, their understanding, love, and guidance were my greatest sources of strength.

Equally, I am grateful for everyone I met during my college years. From my peers in the Chenxi Service Society to the friends I collaborated with on various public service projects and volunteer activities, each of you brought light and significance to my undergraduate experience. Thank you for walking alongside me and inspiring me with your kindness and dedication.

My appreciation also extends to the faculty of the School of International and Public Affairs, where I completed my minor. The curriculum helped broaden my perspective and refine my academic interests. Although my graduate admissions journey did not lead me back to the School, I sincerely hope that one day I may return for doctoral studies and continue my exploration of public affairs.

Looking ahead, I hope to remain grounded and persistent—a dream chaser who moves forward with quiet determination. I aspire to be a courageous and confident individual, unafraid of uncertainty and willing to work hard for a future I believe in.

In summary, I would like to express my gratitude to the School of Foreign Languages—its professors, classmates, and every teacher who believed in me. I also want to thank the part of me that once doubted my abilities in the realm of literature. My appreciation extends to the School of International and Public Affairs, as well as to the like-minded companions I met through public service. I am grateful to everyone I have encountered during these invaluable years. Above all, thank you, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, for providing me with the opportunity to stumble, learn, grow, and dream.